

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 27-29

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 27

Wagon of the Bonepickers

THE SOLDIERS CONTINUED their search, burning blankets and questioning Choctaws at every camp. By noon they arrived at the wagon of the bonepickers, the final stop.

I stepped through the walls of the trunk to warn Naomi.

"They are here," I whispered.

"Did they hurt my family?" she asked.

"No, your family is safe, but Leader is furious. He wants to hurt you. Whatever happens, don't make a sound."

"I am ready for this day to be over," she said. "My body is stiff from lying here so long."

“You won’t have long to wait,” I said. The words had barely left my lips when the soldiers stormed into camp. I waited for Leader to bark his orders. I heard the horses shuffling around the wagon, but Leader was silent. I lifted myself from the trunk and floated through the wagon.

Leader waved his arms and motioned for the soldiers to dismount. The bonepickers huddled together in the wagon.

“Where is everyone?” Roundman asked.

Leader stared hard at him, moving his finger to his lips for silence. He stepped to the wagon and flung the curtain aside.

“Come out, now!” he yelled.

No one moved.

“Get out of the wagon!”

The bonepickers, one by one, climbed from the wagon. They were old and moved so slowly, stepping down with feeble, unsure legs. Leader grew impatient.

“Move!” he shouted. The oldest bonepicker was the last to leave. Her legs were so short her feet dangled in the air, searching a safe place to step. Leader grabbed her by the arm and threw her to the ground. A soldier moved to help her.

“Leave her alone,” Leader said. His chest was heaving back and forth. “Someone will die today,” he said in a mean, low voice, staring hard at the soldier. “It might be you.”

The soldiers froze. They looked at the old woman lying at their feet. I felt the warm shiver washing over me and closed my eyes. When I opened them, I was surrounded by dozens of older *Nahullo* women.

They are spirit people, I thought. Ghosts. *They are the grandmothers, the mothers, and aunts of the soldiers.*

The women wrapped their arms around the soldiers, and though their arms floated through the air, touching nothing, they smiled and talked among themselves. They were overjoyed to see their young men.

The soldiers could not see the ghost women, but their memories were strong. I could see it in their faces. They winced as they stared at the fallen bonepicker.

What if that was my mother? they seemed to be thinking. They looked at Leader, and saw for the first time the cruel man they were bound by law to follow.

Leader shouted at the bonepickers standing before him.

"Where is she? You are hiding the girl, I know it. Speak to me!"

The bonepickers moved to help their fallen friend. *They are frail but they are brave*, I thought.

"Leave her alone!" Leader yelled.

The bonepickers ignored him and he grew madder still.

"Drag everything from the wagon," he said. Two soldiers stepped forward and entered the wagon. I floated in beside them.

"There is blood everywhere," a soldier said. "Nothing here but an old trunk."

“Open it,” Leader said, leaning inside the wagon. The soldier lifted the lid and stepped back in horror.

“The trunk is full of bones,” the soldier said. “They are covered in blood.” Leader turned to the bonepickers.

“What are you hiding?” The bonepickers huddled together and spoke not a word. Nothing Leader did or said meant anything to them.

“I don’t think they understand English,” said Roundman.

“Maybe they will understand this,” Leader replied. He stepped to the campfire, picked up a burning log, and handed it to Roundman.

“Burn the wagon,” he said in a quiet voice.

No! I thought. Naomi is still inside.

“Please help her,” Nita whispered in my ear. I entered the wagon and tried to lift the lid, but my hands passed through the trunk. Roundman tossed the burning log in the wagon. The dry wood and cloth caught fire and the wagon burst into flames.

From his hiding place in the cedar trees, Joseph saw everything. He leapt from a low hanging branch and landed near the wagon.

“Grab him!” Leader shouted. A soldier tackled Joseph and wrestled him to the ground.

“Well,” said Leader, “we thought the panther killed you.”

Joseph said nothing. Flames shot into the sky, and soon the wagon was a tower of fire. Scorching heat cracked the air. The soldiers covered their faces and stepped back. Joseph relaxed and the soldier loosened his grip, just enough.

Joseph wiggled free and dashed to the wagon. He leapt through the burning curtain as the soldier grabbed his legs.

“Let him go,” said Leader. “My prophecy comes true. Let him burn.”

Nita and I entered the smoke-filled wagon. Flames crept up the walls of the trunk. Joseph flung open the lid and tossed the bones aside. He lifted the false floor and pulled Naomi to her feet. She was covered in blood and looked more dead than alive.

“We are here for you,” Joseph said. Naomi shook with fear, but her face looked strong. Somehow I knew she would live through this day.

“They are watching the rear of the wagon,” Joseph yelled, over the sound of the crackling flames. “We’ll jump through the cloth wall.”

He ripped a piece of burning wood from the floor and held it to the cloth. The flames ignited and they waited for the circle of fire to grow. Naomi slapped embers from her hair and clothes.

“They are waiting too long,” I said. “They will burn to death.”

“No,” said Nita. “They know what they’re doing.”

As the roof of the wagon collapsed in a mound of flames, Joseph took Naomi by the hand and they jumped from the wagon. By the time they were spotted, they were almost to the river.

“After them!” Leader yelled, but his voice was drowned out by the sound of the wagon crashing. All eyes remained on the burning wagon — and the bonepickers huddled together quietly and unafraid of death.

While the soldiers watched, the women kicked aside the still burning boards, searching for any remaining bones.

Leader jumped on his horse and rode after Joseph and Naomi. They dashed to the river, with Leader close behind. It looked like he would catch them, but his horse slipped on a rock overhang and Leader jerked the reins. His horse bucked and sent Leader flying from the saddle.

His head struck hard against the rock. Blood gushed from a gash on his forehead, but he scrambled to his feet.

“They’re safe for now, Nita,” I said. I knew they could outrun him. Leader was staggering. He grabbed a tree trunk to steady himself.

Suddenly, Naomi stopped.

“Run,” said Joseph. “Follow me. I know a place to hide.”

Naomi shook her head and pointed to a dark cavern beneath the rock. I followed her gaze and froze in terror at what I saw. I closed my eyes, hoping this was all a ghost vision, a terrible vision that would go away.

Please, don't let this happen, I thought.



Chapter 28

Panther and the Wolf

WHEN I OPENED my eyes, the wolf that had killed me was crawling from the cavern. He lowered his head and stared at Naomi, then slowly turned his head to look at Joseph. He bared his teeth and growled a low growl. He lifted his head and sniffed the air.

“He smells the blood,” Joseph whispered. “Don’t move, Naomi.”

The wolf leapt on the stone overhang and spotted Leader, leaning against the tree.

Someone will die today.

Leader’s vow hung in the air. The wolf crouched, ready to pounce.

“We cannot let this happen,” Naomi said. She looked to Joseph, but Joseph was no longer at her side. He was now the panther. He lifted himself on his hind legs, swatted the air with his claws, and let fly a piercing scream.

Leader came to his senses. He saw the wolf crouched in front of him. He covered his face with his hands as the wolf leapt for his throat.

The wolf never reached him. The panther took two quick steps, caught the wolf in mid-air, and flung him to the ground.

The fight was over in a heartbeat. The panther sank his claws into the belly of the wolf. He locked his jaws around the wolf’s head and lifted him off the ground, swinging him back and forth till the wolf was limp and lifeless. He dropped the dead wolf at the feet of Leader.

“Now,” I said. “We have to go!”

Following Naomi, we circled the tree. Leader sank to the ground. I came to life before him, and Nita joined me. Leader shook in fear.

“Who are you?” he said, trembling. We looked to the panther. Shiny black fur sank into his skin, his clothes appeared, and Joseph soon stood among us.

“You are the panther,” Leader said. “That is how you survived that night in the cave.”

“Yes,” Joseph said. “I am the panther. And the boy you tried to kill.”

“And you,” he whispered, looking at Naomi. “I vowed that you would die today. Why did you save me?”

“It was the right thing to do,” said Naomi. “It is the Choctaw way.”

Leader looked hard at us. With the threat on his life gone, we saw his strength return. Leader kicked the wolf, and the carcass lifted from the ground. It fell at Naomi's feet, splattering blood in all directions.

Hearing the scuffle, the soldiers dashed to the river. They aimed their shotguns at Naomi and Joseph.

"One move and we will shoot you both," Roundman shouted.

"Put down your weapons," Leader said. "That is an order. We will return to our wagons now."

He turned to Naomi. "You have earned your life today," Leader said. "You can return to your parents. But there will be another day." For a moment that stretched into forever, we stood in silence and watched Leader walk away.

I felt a strong shiver and breathed a sigh of relief. Hundreds of Choctaw ghosts appeared, encircling us. A stout old Choctaw man stepped forward.

"I have heard of you young Choctaws," he said, casting a slow gaze at Joseph, Naomi, Nita, and myself. "I want you to know that I walk with you now."

"Who are you?" Naomi asked. "I think I have seen your face."

"I am Chief Pushmataha," the man said.

"My grandfather spoke of you," said Joseph. "You are General Pushmataha. You fought at the Battle of New Orleans."

"Yes," Pushmataha said, smiling. "I was a general in the United States Army. I come today to honor four young Choctaw heroes. You are brave and you are honest. Young men, you rescued an innocent Choctaw. She will never

forget how you risked your life to save her. Young lady, you saved a man's life today. You did the right thing."

We hung our heads, proud and embarrassed both.

"I hope you will never forget this day," Pushmataha continued. "Always remember, we Choctaws are a strong people, a good people. We fight to protect two nations, the United States of America and the Choctaw Nation."

"Yakoke," we said.

"Yakoke to you," Chief Pushmataha said, lifting his arms.

The gathered throng of Choctaws, a thousand strong, lifted their arms and whispered, *"Yakoke,"* sending their thank you to the heavens. The trees rustled in the wake of a soft breeze.



Chapter 29

Pushmataha and the Choctaw Four

BY DAY'S END, the bonepickers had a new wagon and the burned blankets were replaced, as ordered by Leader. The soldiers delivered bags filled with ears of corn to every wagon of walkers. Naomi was reunited with her mother and father, and that very evening she insisted on helping with the cooking.

"Please," she said. "I can't sit still and be waited on."

"But this is your first day with your family," her mother said. "We are celebrating your return."

"Nothing will make me happier than to cook for my family, my bigger family," she said, looking at Luke and my mother and father.

"I want to help, too," said Joseph.

She and Joseph built a fire, fanning the sparks till yellow and blue flames flickered and danced and warmed the air. Naomi and her mother, Ruth, boiled the corn to a thick broth, stirring the pot and smiling. Nita and I joined the gathering, in full view of everyone.

The Trail still lay before us. The winter was fierce and food was scarce, but our most feared enemy, Leader, left us alone to be with our families. We met a new friend and protector that day, as well.

We knew we would see General Pushmataha for many days and years to come.

"Chi pisa lachike," he told us, as he floated from our sight. "I will see you again."